

offered by major platforms, making it harder for D2C brands to compete directly in this space.

Q Are you expanding into other product categories beyond TVs? Could you share details about these new ventures?

A Yes, we are diversifying our product portfolio. A few years ago, TVs accounted for 100% of our business; today, they contribute about 70%, which we expect to decrease to around 65% as we enter new categories. We've ventured into washing machines under the Thomson and White-Westinghouse brands, experiencing over 120% growth. We've also started producing air coolers and set up our own manufacturing plant. Additionally, we've launched Thomson speakers, starting with two models and planning to introduce about 20-25 new models in the upcoming year. We're gearing up to focus more on air conditioners as well. Diversifying into these categories has yielded excellent results so far.

Q Are these new products manufactured in-house or imported? How is SPPL approaching manufacturing and R&D?

A All these products, except for air conditioners, are manufactured in-house. We don't rely on Original Equipment Manufacturers (OEMs) or Original Design Manufacturers (ODMs). Our approach focuses on backward integration and in-house production to maintain quality and control. By investing in our manufacturing facilities and R&D, we can innovate and respond quickly to market demands, maintaining a competitive edge and delivering value to our customers.

Q What technological trends are shaping the TV industry, and what features are consumers demanding the most?

A Mini-LED technology is a significant development in the television industry. With OLED prices remaining

high and limited panel availability from LG, mini-LED offers a competitive alternative. If mini-LED becomes more affordable, it could be the next big disruption, rivalling OLED in performance but at a lower cost. However, consumer education is crucial, as the term "mini" may mislead some into thinking it's a lesser technology.

Advanced features like Google Assistant with voice control are also in high demand, making voice the

Q How important is panel technology, such as VA vs. IPS panels, in today's TVs? Are consumers concerned about these differences?

A In today's market, the distinction between VA and IPS panels in TVs has diminished. Manufacturing is concentrated in China, and brands source panels based on availability and price. Consumers are primarily driven by price and overall specs rather than the type of panel. The focus on VA vs.



new user interface. As OTT streaming becomes more prevalent, consumers seek a cinematic experience at home, so features enhancing picture and sound quality, such as Dolby Vision and Dolby Atmos, are increasingly important. Sound quality improvements and connectivity options like dual-band Wi-Fi and Bluetooth are also priorities for today's tech-savvy consumers.

Q Do you see technologies like micro-LED becoming mainstream soon, and how do they compare with mini-LED?

A Micro-LED is the next step in display technology, offering superior lighting control and picture quality. However, it's currently expensive and mainly found in flagship TVs. Mini-LEDs are more accessible and set to become mainstream much sooner. By 2025, I believe mini-LED technology will be widely adopted by affordable brands, offering significant improvements in black levels and overall picture quality.

IPS was significant a few years ago but doesn't influence buying decisions as much now.

Q How do you see the impact of GST rates on the TV industry, and what changes do you advocate for?

A GST rates significantly impact the TV industry. Currently, TVs above a certain size are taxed at a higher rate, affecting pricing and sales volumes. Despite signs of market de-growth in units sold, the government's reluctance to reduce GST rates is a concern. We believe that lowering GST rates on TVs would encourage more consumers to purchase new, larger screen sizes, boosting the industry. We've been engaging with government officials and plan to raise this issue in future GST Council meetings. It's important for the government to consider the long-term benefits of adjusting GST rates for industry growth and increased consumer satisfaction. **d**